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Whitepaper

Empowering the Frontline Retail Workforce With AI

How Databricks and Accenture are reinventing retail through the power of human and machine intelligence



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01 Introduction

We're living in unprecedented times. At one end, we're facing geopolitical uncertainties, and at the other, we're on the precipice of transformative opportunity.

Consumer industries, especially retail, are at the forefront of these contrasting forces. These organizations are seeking to transform faster, build more agility and accelerate core business operations.

Consumer industries are in the eye of the storm. Impacted by both macroeconomic disruptions and changing expectations from consumers, their most promising weapon remains the ubiquitous nature of generative AI (GenAI) and agentic AI — technologies that have the potential to fundamentally shift how work gets done today and into the future.

These uncertain times put tremendous strain on the workforce, triggering hiring freezes, shifting talent needs, role relocations and low morale. With people being a key driver of organizations' success, the only option for CEOs is to support their workforces with clarity and purpose.

GenAI can be a critical enabler. By empowering decision-making and reducing workload stress for employees through AI-enabled next best action tools, businesses can shift toward meaningful work, faster upskilling and more engaged employees. Agentic AI amplifies this impact by autonomously handling routine or semi-complex decisions while ensuring human oversight for critical judgment calls.

The change is coming. According to an Accenture survey of 3,000 C-suite executives, 90% say the pace of change has accelerated since earlier this year. GenAI and agentic AI will play pivotal roles in this change, giving these leaders powerful levers with which to reshape how people work. On average, GenAI will impact over 45% of employee hours across both frontline and corporate roles in consumer industries. And according to Forrester, GenAI software spending is projected to grow at a 36% compound annual growth rate through 2030.

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While many companies have defined corporate AI strategies, few have addressed the needs of frontline teams such as store associates, fulfillment center staff, distribution workers and service employees.

In this whitepaper, we examine how GenAI and agentic AI will transform four key areas of frontline experience:

- Shifting job roles, skills requirements and hiring practices
- Enhanced consumer interactions
- Efficiency gains and enhanced productivity
- Improved worker sentiment

Databricks and Accenture bring complementary strengths to this transformation. Accenture leads change management and workforce modernization, while Databricks provides the Data Intelligence Platform that powers AI adoption at scale — lowering costs, accelerating time to value and ensuring trust across the entire data lifecycle. Together, generative AI and agentic AI enable frontline teams to access insights and execute context-aware actions, freeing employees to focus on high-value human tasks and decision-making.

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Shifting job roles, skills requirements and hiring practices

According to the National Retail Federation (NRF), the retail industry supports over 55 million full-time and part-time jobs, accounting for 26% of total U.S. employment. These employees are central to a brand's ability to provide personalized consumer experiences and services, but frontline workers are under tremendous stress due to erratic schedules, repetitive tasks, an extremely high volume of customer interaction and many other daily challenges. GenAI and agentic AI can fundamentally shift frontline roles in the following ways:

- **A more human-centered approach** — As GenAI and agentic AI take over mundane and repeatable tasks, frontline workers can focus more on empathy, judgement, creativity and complex problem-solving situations. Agentic AI additionally enables workers to delegate semi-autonomous decision-making tasks, allowing for faster execution without compromising human oversight.
- **Enhanced capabilities** — While GenAI solutions can automate certain repeatable and mundane tasks, their core strength is in augmenting these frontline workers to perform better. GenAI can learn from best practices and standard operating procedures, then make them available to all frontline workers to dramatically increase effectiveness. This is where the Databricks unified approach plays a critical role: By combining all structured and unstructured data in a governed, secure environment, teams can build onboarding and upskilling agents that are accurate, compliant and actionable in real time. For example, agentic AI agents can act on these insights directly, e.g., prioritizing tasks or initiating actions, further enhancing efficiency and impact.
- **Evolution of management roles** — Store managers, warehouse managers and department heads can access insights through simple, conversational interfaces. With Databricks AI/BI Genie, they can get reliable data and recommendations instantly — shifting from tactical execution to strategic action. With agentic AI, managers can receive real-time alerts and action recommendations, ensuring they intervene only when necessary and enabling them to focus on strategic initiatives.

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Organizations will need to upskill frontline workers to effectively use AI tools, understand how to interpret AI-generated insights and adapt to new workflows. Companies that focus on and invest in AI literacy and change management programs will realize maximum benefit. Hiring practices will change to either source digitally native talent or identify employees who are willing to embrace the new ways of working. GenAI and agentic AI will help companies reduce cycle times from requisition to onboarding — often from 12–16 weeks to just 6–8 weeks — using AI-driven screening and personalized training plans.

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Enhanced consumer interactions

Consumer preferences are continually shifting. According to the OECD Consumer Barometer, consumer outlook has shifted from "Hopeful & Eager" to "Cautious & Uncertain" to potentially "Bearish & Anxious" in a span of 18 months. Today's digitally native shoppers, particularly Gen Z and beyond, want it all: personalization, immediacy and meaningful loyalty. The number of Gen Z consumers in the U.S. who say they belong to a loyalty program has jumped 15% year over year.

Frontline workers are the face of a brand for these consumer interactions. GenAI and agentic AI have the ability to create moments that matter, elevating their impact through:

Improved in-store personalized experiences — While e-commerce will continue to rise, physical stores are making their presence felt for brands as experiential spaces. GenAI and agentic AI have the potential to convert every frontline worker into a clienteling expert. With access to personalized recommendations, insights and subject matter expertise on categories or products at their fingertips, frontline workers can focus on shopper intent, not just transactions. Additionally, AI agents can be relied on to proactively suggest actions to employees based on customer behavior and historical data, creating frictionless, tailored experiences.

Streamlined customer service and digital touchpoints — With physical stores becoming part of the experiential space for brands, agentic AI can enhance and streamline in-store interactions such as returns. It can also provide digital touchpoints like virtual try-ons and in-store merchandise customization. This empowers frontline workers to drive consumer loyalty and revenue by creating memorable, loyalty-building experiences.

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To meet these expectations, brands must rethink their store experiences and equip frontline staff with the tools and AI capabilities to match. With Databricks lakehouse architecture and AI, real-time, governed and personalized support becomes scalable across hundreds — or thousands — of stores.

Efficiency gains and enhanced productivity

Frontline retail workers juggle a lot of things: shift schedules, guidelines, checklists, inventory details, standard operating procedures and more. All while facing concerns around safety and burnout.

By combining GenAI, agentic AI and physical AI (integration of AI with physical systems like robots and self-driving cars) with real-time streaming analytics and predictive modeling (enabled by Databricks lakehouse architecture and Lakeflow), organizations can drive step-change productivity:

- **Automate the mundane, augment the reasoning** — GenAI can take over repetitive, time-consuming tasks such as answering frequently asked questions, processing returns and exchanges, basic onboarding procedures for new employees and even generating automated reports and analyses for store managers. Agentic AI goes a step further by autonomously executing decisions within defined boundaries, such as triggering reorder requests, assigning tasks to available staff or initiating preventative maintenance. This helps to reduce the need for constant human oversight while maintaining control and compliance, and frees up frontline workers to focus on higher-value activities. AI can also optimize task lists, trigger alerts for issues (e.g., spoilage detection) and provide predictive maintenance recommendations for equipment, improving overall store efficiency.
- **Improved access to information and insights** — Historically, frontline workers lacked access to real-time insights. With advances in AI, chatbots and knowledge bases can provide instant access to product details, store policies, inventory levels and even troubleshooting steps for equipment. Employees can instantly query a knowledge base, reducing the time they spend searching for information or waiting for supervisor responses, making them more informed and responsive.
- **Functional support** — The convergence of GenAI and technologies like edge computing and computer vision can change the way stores manage loss prevention. GenAI can analyze sales and inventory data, monitor surveillance footage for suspicious behavior and detect fraud, reducing losses and allowing associates to focus on customer service. Agentic AI can automatically flag anomalies, recommend interventions or execute preapproved countermeasures. This further enhances store operations, optimizes supply chains and delivery routes and helps products reach stores faster and more efficiently — indirectly supporting frontline workers by ensuring product availability.

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According to MIT Technology Review, 74% of global enterprises have adopted lakehouse technology to unify data, analytics and AI workloads.

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Investing in GenAI and agentic AI for frontline workers solves multiple productivity challenges. Even a fractional increase in efficiency across the workforce can produce outsized gains, especially when repeated across thousands of locations. By enabling semi-autonomous execution of routine and structured tasks, agentic AI magnifies the impact of human labor while keeping employees focused on strategic, customer-centric work.

Improved worker sentiment

Many frontline workers have not fully recovered from the COVID-19 disruption. Nearly three-quarters of the employees who left their jobs since 2020 have left the industry altogether. Interestingly, the shift in employee priorities means that the top reason for employees leaving their jobs, for both managers and non-managers, has been career development.

GenAI and agentic AI can serve as a lever that can reduce employee stress, demonstrate an organization's commitment to upskilling and career development and allay fears workers may have around job displacement due to AI.

- **Burnout prevention** — AI can help reduce burnout by automating repetitive tasks, providing 24/7 query support and streamlining HR functions like shift viewing and time recording. The use of AI agents can automate the handling of scheduling conflicts, alert supervisors only when exceptions occur and recommend workload balancing — further reducing stress and cognitive load, while empowering workers to focus on more rewarding aspects of their jobs.
- **Close the digital gap** — While corporate roles often benefit from advanced tooling first, organizations that prioritize user-friendly AI tools for frontline teams can drive faster adoption, better morale and long-term retention. For instance, agentic AI can bridge the digital gap by acting as a proactive assistant, providing guidance, recommendations and actions that align with worker goals and organizational policies.
- **Improved morale** — Gartner predicts that by 2028, 20% of repetitive processes will be automated by domain-specific GenAI implementations across industries. While a significant portion of frontline workers (over 4 in 10) are concerned about AI replacing their jobs in the next decade, upskilling and equipping them with AI skills and AI agents will significantly reduce their fear of replacement, improving both confidence and morale.

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When applied thoughtfully, GenAI has the potential to transform the roles of retail frontline workers by making them more efficient, data driven and focused on high-value customer interactions. However, successful adoption hinges on careful implementation, robust training and a human-centered approach that prioritizes augmenting human capabilities rather than simply automating jobs. With deep industry expertise, Accenture designs tailored frontline AI solutions that, when built on the Databricks Data Intelligence Platform, scale securely and effectively across the enterprise.

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A Human-Centered, Data-Driven Future

Databricks and Accenture share a common belief: The future of AI in consumer industries isn't about replacing people, it's about unlocking their full potential.

Databricks provides the open, unified Data Intelligence Platform built for governed, scalable AI. Accenture brings deep industry expertise and proven change management capabilities. Together, we help organizations:

- Lower the cost to scale AI across frontline and corporate teams
- Democratize access to real-time data and insights
- Empower employees through trusted, human-centered and agentic AI

The result is a more agile, motivated and effective workforce. One that's ready for the demands of today and tomorrow.

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Discover how Databricks and Accenture are enabling retailers to unlock productivity, enhance store operations and build more agile, engaged frontline teams. Contact us today.

About Databricks

Databricks is the data and AI company. More than 15,000 organizations worldwide — including Block, Comcast, Condé Nast, Rivian, Shell and over 60% of the Fortune 500 — rely on the Databricks Data Intelligence Platform to build AI apps and agents on their enterprise data. Headquartered in San Francisco with offices around the globe, Databricks offers a unified platform that includes Agent Bricks, Databricks SQL, Lakebase, Lakeflow and Unity Catalog. To learn more, follow Databricks on LinkedIn, X, YouTube and Instagram.

About Accenture

Accenture is a leading global professional services company that helps the world's leading organizations build their digital core, optimize their operations, accelerate revenue growth and enhance services — creating tangible value at speed and scale. We are a talent- and innovation-led company with 774,000 people serving clients in more than 120 countries. Technology is at the core of change today, and we are one of the world's leaders in helping drive that change, with strong ecosystem relationships. We combine our strength in technology and leadership in cloud, data and AI with unmatched industry experience, functional expertise and global delivery capability. Our broad range of services, solutions and assets across Strategy & Consulting, Technology, Operations, Industry X and Song, together with our culture of shared success and commitment to creating 360° value, enable us to help our clients reinvent and build trusted, lasting relationships. We measure our success by the 360° value we create for our clients, each other, our shareholders, partners and communities. Visit us at www.accenture.com.

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